

Episode 73: Year-End Extra Edition – What I Thought After Going to Osaka

Huh? (sweat)

Christmas is over already, isn't it? (sweat)

Which means next week is already next year, right? (sweat)

This work I'm doing colour direction for now, this episode number, wasn't this supposed to be delivered by year-end? (sweat)

What's going on?? (heavy sweat)

Anyway, this is the last instalment of the year, so I'm writing this manuscript, but out of 52 weeks in a year, how many manuscripts did I end up writing?

Hmm...

Anyway, next year, I really need to... not drop any manuscripts... as much as possible.

...I'll do my best (sobbing).

Now then.

Last weekend, I went to Osaka to see Oda Kazumasa's concert at Kyocera Dome.

Actually, I'm a big fan of Oda Kazumasa, and I follow his concert tours every few years, watching not only Tokyo performances but also quite a few performances outside Tokyo. I get tickets for concerts held on weekends in regional areas and use the concerts

as an excuse to tour those regions - that's my pattern for domestic travel. This year alone, I went to Takamatsu, Sapporo, Hakata, and Nagoya (laughs).

So, Osaka. It's been a while since I've been to Osaka.

Every time I go to Osaka, I think "Ah, it's different from Tokyo. It's like a foreign country."

Well, of course, since they're speaking a different language, it's natural. For example, on station escalators. In Tokyo, you stand on the left and leave the right side open, but in Osaka this is reversed. It's the same not just in Osaka, but also in Kyushu and Fukuoka. Incidentally, it's the same in Seoul, Korea (laughs). Somehow it makes me think "Ah! Asia!" (laughs).

What struck me as "interesting" this time were the subway car advertisements. The so-called Tokyo-originated ads from major national companies weren't particularly different from those in Tokyo, but what was interesting were the local corporate and regional ads. Local Osaka eyeglass stores, pachinko parlours, "debt consultation" law offices - various ads were there, and their colour usage was interesting. There were tonnes of combinations like "there's no way you'd use this text colour with this background colour!" (laughs). Looking around, I could see that such colour schemes actually formed a trend. Which means these are "acceptable" in Osaka, I suppose.

Starting from such observations, when I looked at the downtown areas and station crowds, the atmosphere of the city and the aura carried by the people passing by were definitely somehow different from the Tokyo where I live. This isn't limited to Osaka - it's the same in other regional cities too, though to varying degrees. But you know, places like Sapporo don't seem to have such big differences, and ah, maybe that's because my mother was born in Hokkaido?

I was born and raised in Tokyo. I'm still living in Tokyo now, but we people born and raised in Tokyo tend to have the illusion that Tokyo things are standard wherever you go in the country. We live in the country called Japan, speak roughly

the same Japanese, watch the same nationally broadcast network programmes on TV as Tokyo, and see the same nationwide corporate advertisements as Tokyo. But you know, everything else has surprisingly big differences.

So I thought: "How do dramas and anime made in Tokyo appear to people living outside Tokyo?" Those of us living normally in Tokyo watch Tokyo-set dramas with no sense of incongruity, just thinking "hmm, okay," but how do people in regional areas watching these feel?

For example, TV dramas set in Tokyo streets, right? And there are escalator scenes where people stand on the left and leave the right open because it's Tokyo - that's normal, right? But what do people in Osaka and Hakata think when they watch this? Does this slight difference from their daily life create a sense of incongruity when compared to their reality? Or is it just "the world inside TV"?

In anime's case, when it becomes stories about other worlds, it probably doesn't matter much, but for example, school stories and contemporary dramas often have settings in Tokyo or its suburbs. So those "little things" that we casually treat as "well, this is how it is, right?" based on Tokyo standards in our visuals - in reality, might not be that way outside Tokyo.

The *Ojamajo Doremi* (おジャ魔女どれみ) series was also made with a "roughly Tokyo suburbs, maybe Kanagawa-ish?" feeling. While thinking about creating an atmosphere that viewers could easily and naturally accept, we aimed for something "relatively standard-looking nationally," but I wonder how it appeared to all those who watched it nationwide?

Well, such were the various things I thought about vaguely while eating delicious food in Osaka (laughs).

Oh, speaking of which, back during *Doremi*, when Nagamine-kun was going to direct Ai-chan's hometown story, he actually went on "self-funded research" to Tennoji in Osaka. I remembered such things while eating kushikatsu under Tsutenkaku (laughs).

(08.12.26)